

Nookix Book Summary

We Should All Be Feminists Summary

by Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie

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Book Overview: Why We Must Reclaim Feminism

Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie was fourteen years old when a childhood friend named Okoloma called her a feminist. She didn't know what the word meant. But she could tell from his tone that it was not a compliment.

The two were arguing about something—Adichie can't remember what—when Okoloma dropped the label like an accusation. She let it pass in the moment. Later, she looked it up in a dictionary. The definition she found was simple: a feminist is a person who believes in the social, political, and economic equality of the sexes.

But the gap between that definition and the way Okoloma said the word stayed with her. It became the seed of an essay that would eventually reach millions of people around the world.

That essay is *We Should All Be Feminists*. Adapted from Adichie's 2012 TEDx talk, it is a slim, powerful manifesto that aims to do one thing: challenge the stereotypes that have made the word "feminist" feel like an insult rather than a statement of belief in equality.

Okoloma died in a plane crash in 2005. Adichie still mourns him. But his dismissal of feminism—the assumption that calling someone a feminist was a way to put them down—represents exactly the problem the essay seeks to address. The word carries so much negative baggage that its actual meaning gets buried.

Adichie's core argument is disarmingly straightforward. A feminist is simply someone who believes men and women should be equal. That's it. No more, no less. And if we accept that gender equality is a worthy goal, then the logical conclusion is in the title: we should all be feminists.

But getting to that simple conclusion requires clearing away the noise. Throughout the essay, Adichie uses personal stories to show how gender inequality operates in everyday life—not just in obvious forms like workplace discrimination, but in the small, repeated moments that tell women they matter less.

The memory of Okoloma frames the entire book. It opens with his accusation and closes with Adichie reclaiming the word he used against her. She writes that Okoloma was right to call her a feminist—but for the wrong reasons. He meant it as a dismissal. She now wears it as a badge of clarity.

This section introduces the central conflict of the essay: the distance between what feminism actually means and what people think it means. It also establishes why the conversation matters. Gender inequality is not a thing of the past. It persists in how children are raised, how workplaces are structured, how strangers treat women in restaurants and taxis. And it harms everyone—men and women alike.

Adichie does not lecture. She tells stories. She invites the reader into her world—a childhood in Nigeria, a friendship with Okoloma, the moment she first encountered the word that would come to define so much of her public life. That approach makes the essay feel like a conversation rather than a sermon.

The question she leaves us with is this: If the word "feminist" simply means believing in equality, why does it still provoke such strong reactions? And what would it take to reclaim it?

The Negative Baggage of the 'F-Word'

The word "feminist" had a habit of arriving wrapped in warnings. After Okoloma's dismissive tone, Adichie encountered others who seemed to feel it was their duty to protect her from the label. A Nigerian journalist interviewed her after the publication of her first novel, *Purple Hibiscus*. He was friendly, complimentary, even encouraging. Then came the advice. He told her, with what seemed like genuine concern, that she should not call herself a feminist. Why? Because feminists were unhappy women. Because they could not find husbands. Because the label itself was a kind of social poison that would drive people away.

Adichie was taken aback. She had not even called herself a feminist in the interview. Yet the warning arrived anyway, as if the journalist could smell the word lurking beneath her answers. The message was clear: being a feminist was a liability. It marked you as bitter, unlovable, angry at the world for reasons that were probably your own fault.

This was not an isolated incident. A female Nigerian academic told her that feminism was not African. It was a Western import, she said, incompatible with Nigerian culture and values. The implication stung: to be a feminist was to be un-African, to betray your heritage, to reject your own people. Another woman, a friend, warned her that men found feminists intimidating and aggressive. The advice was always the same: soften the label, qualify it, apologize for it, or better yet, drop it entirely.

The stereotypes piled up like baggage no one asked to carry. Feminists hate men, people said. They hate bras. They hate African culture. They think women should always be in charge. They don't wear makeup. They don't shave. They're always angry. They have no sense of humor. They don't use deodorant. The list was absurd, almost comical in its reach, and that was exactly Adichie's point. The word "feminist" had been buried under so many false associations that its real meaning had become nearly impossible to see.

So Adichie did what any reasonable person might do when faced with an avalanche of stereotypes: she tried to work around them. She began calling herself a "Happy Feminist." Then a "Happy African Feminist." Then, with a growing sense of irony and exhaustion, she adopted the full, unwieldy title: "a Happy African Feminist Who Does Not Hate Men and Who Likes to Wear Lip Gloss and High Heels for Herself and Not For Men."

She capitalized it, as if it were an official designation. The humor was intentional. The point was to show how ridiculous the situation had become. A woman could not simply say "I am a feminist" without immediately launching into a defensive catalog of disclaimers. She had to prove she was not angry, not man-hating, not unfeminine, not a threat. She had to apologize for the label before anyone would even hear what she meant by it.

The journalist's warning had stuck with her. Not because it was cruel—it wasn't, at least not intentionally—but because it revealed something deeper. The word "feminist" had been so thoroughly demonized that even well-meaning people felt obligated to steer women away from it. They were not trying to hurt her. They were trying to protect her from a reputation they themselves believed was deserved.

But here was the problem: the stereotypes did not match reality. Adichie did not hate men. She loved her father, her brother, her male friends. She did not hate African culture. She was deeply interested in her Igbo heritage, frustrated only by the parts that excluded her because she was a woman. She wore makeup when she felt like it. She wore lip gloss and high heels for herself, not to please anyone. She was angry sometimes, yes—but anger at injustice was not the same as being perpetually bitter. And she had a sense of humor, as her ironic self-labeling made abundantly clear.

The effort to distance herself from the stereotype became exhausting. Every time she introduced herself as a feminist, she had to preemptively dismantle assumptions she had not created. The burden was always on her to prove she was the "right kind" of feminist—the acceptable kind, the non-threatening kind, the kind people could tolerate without feeling uncomfortable.

And yet, even as she played along with this game of qualification, she knew something was wrong with it. Why should anyone have to apologize for believing in equality? Why should a simple word require so much explanation? The journalist who warned her was not a bad person. The academic who told her feminism was un-African was not malicious. They were products of a society that had trained them to see feminism as a problem rather than a solution.

The weight of these stereotypes was not just personal. It was political. It kept people from embracing an idea that could improve their lives. If the word "feminist" had been so thoroughly poisoned that even its supporters felt the need to distance themselves from it, then the work of reclaiming it had to begin with clearing away the noise.

Adichie's long, ironic title was a way of saying: look at what I have to do just to be heard. Look at how much I have to explain before anyone will listen to what I actually believe. The humor made the point without bitterness, but the frustration underneath was real.

She had not asked for this baggage. None of it was hers to carry. But the stereotypes had been laid at her feet anyway, and she had to decide what to do with them. She could keep apologizing, keep qualifying, keep proving she was the right kind of feminist. Or she could stop. She could simply state what she meant and let the word stand on its own.

The journalist had meant well. But his warning revealed something important: the fight for equality would never succeed if people could not even say the word without flinching. Reclaiming feminism meant reclaiming the right to name yourself without having to apologize for it first.

Childhood Lessons in Gender Hierarchy

The stereotypes around the word "feminist" were not the only thing Adichie had to unlearn. Long before anyone warned her about what to call herself, she had already been taught a much more fundamental lesson: that boys lead and girls follow. This lesson came not from a lecture or a book, but from a single moment in a primary school classroom, a moment so ordinary that no one else in the room seemed to notice anything had happened.

She was nine years old. The teacher announced that whoever scored highest on the next test would become class monitor. For a nine-year-old, this was not a small thing. The class monitor got to stand at the front, to keep order, to write down names of misbehaving students. It was a position of real authority in a child's world. Adichie wanted it badly. She studied hard, determined to win.

When the results came, she had done exactly what she set out to do. She had the highest score. She was thrilled. But then the teacher made an announcement that made no sense to the nine-year-old girl: the role would go to a boy who had scored second. When Adichie protested, the teacher explained that the class monitor "had to be a boy."

No one else questioned this. The teacher did not apologize. She did not seem to think she was doing anything unfair. To her, it was obvious. The idea that a girl could hold authority over boys was simply not a possibility that crossed her mind. She had not even thought to mention it before the test. It was not a rule that needed stating.

Adichie remembers this moment not with bitterness but with clarity. What struck her then, and what strikes her still, is how the teacher said it. The words "had to be a boy" carried no malice, no awareness of injustice. They were spoken the way someone might say "the sky is blue" or "water is wet." The assumption was so deeply buried in the culture that it had become invisible. The teacher was not a bad person. She was simply passing on a lesson she herself had learned long ago: that the world belongs to men.

This is how inequality works, Adichie explains. It does not require cruelty. It does not need villains. It needs only repetition. When a child sees only men in positions of power, over and over again, that child begins to believe that this is how things are supposed to be. When a girl is passed over for a leadership role because of her gender, and no one objects, she learns that her ambition must have limits. When a boy is given that role even though he did not earn it, he learns that his gender alone is enough.

What we see repeatedly becomes normal. And what is normal becomes invisible. That is why the teacher did not think to announce the rule beforehand. The rule was not a rule at all. It was simply the way things were.

Adichie points out that this pattern does not just hurt girls. The boy who became class monitor was described as quiet and mild-mannered. He had not asked to be put in charge. He had not earned it. But he was given

authority anyway, not because of who he was, but because of what he was. He too was being shaped by expectations he had not chosen. The cage of gender was being built around him as well.

For Adichie, the memory of that classroom has never faded. It was her first direct encounter with the idea that her gender would limit her. It was the moment she learned that hard work and ability were not enough if you were a girl. She had done everything right, and it still was not enough. The message was clear: there were invisible rules that no one would tell her about until she broke them.

This is the world that children inherit. It is not a world of explicit laws that say "girls cannot lead." It is a world where the message is carried in the silences, in the assumptions, in the things that go without saying. The teacher did not have to explain why a boy had to be monitor. She did not have to justify it. The culture had already done that work for her.

And that is the point. By the time Adichie was nine years old, the idea of male leadership was so thoroughly normalized that it did not need to be stated. It was just obvious. And what is obvious is very hard to question.

The 'Little Things': Everyday Invisibility and Dismissal

Adichie was having dinner with her friend Louis, a man she describes as intelligent and progressive. When the meal ended, she reached into her own purse, pulled out cash, and handed the parking attendant a tip. The man took the money, looked past Adichie, turned to Louis, and said, "Thank you, sir."

Louis was stunned. He had heard Adichie talk about sexism before, but he had always dismissed it as a problem of the past. Now he had seen it happen in real time. The parking attendant had assumed the money could not possibly belong to the woman who handed it to him. In his mind, the man must have given it to her, or the man must be the one who actually controlled the finances. Either way, the woman was invisible. Her money was not really hers.

This moment changed something for Louis. He had spent years believing that feminism was no longer necessary, that women and men were already equal. But here was a stranger, a man who had never met either of them, making an instant assumption based purely on gender. The tip had come from Adichie's hand. The thanks went to Louis.

Adichie notes that this kind of thing happens to her constantly. In Lagos, waiters and taxi drivers routinely ignore her and address the man she is with, even when she is the one paying. She knows they do not mean harm. She understands intellectually that they are products of a society that teaches men are more important. But knowing something intellectually and feeling it emotionally are two very different things. The sting does not fade with repetition. Each time a waiter looks past her, each time a taxi driver hands change to her male companion, she feels invisible. She feels upset.

These are not dramatic acts of cruelty. No one is shouting at her or denying her a job. But the accumulation of small slights creates a constant background hum of dismissal. It is the waiter who asks the man what the woman would like to eat. It is the hotel clerk who assumes she is a sex worker when she enters alone. It is the club that refuses her entry because she is not accompanied by a man. Each incident on its own seems trivial. Together, they form a wall.

Adichie points out that many men simply do not see these moments. Louis was a good man, an educated man, a man who considered himself an ally. But until the parking attendant thanked him for her money, he had no idea what she was talking about. This is one of the core problems of everyday sexism: if you are not the one experiencing it, it is easy to miss. The waiter who ignores the woman does not announce what he is doing. He just hands the receipt to the man. The assumption is so ingrained that it feels natural. It does not register as an event worth noticing.

But for the woman on the receiving end, it registers every single time. Adichie says she often makes the mistake of thinking that something obvious to her is just as obvious to everyone else. It is not. The parking attendant did not think he was being sexist. He thought he was being polite. He thanked the person he assumed was in charge. That assumption, that automatic deference to male authority, is precisely the problem.

Adichie is careful not to demonize the individuals involved. She does not call the parking attendant a bad person. She understands that he is acting out of cultural training, not malice. But understanding does not erase the hurt. It does not make her feel less invisible. She describes this as a gap between the intellectual and the emotional. She knows the waiter's behavior is not personal. She still feels it personally.

This is the nature of everyday sexism. It is not a single blow but a thousand small cuts. It is the assumption that a woman's voice carries less weight, that her money is not really hers, that her presence is secondary to the man beside her. It is the feeling of being spoken over, looked past, and assumed to be less capable. And because each incident seems so small, women are often told they are overreacting. They are told to let it go. They are told it is not a big deal.

But it is a big deal. It is a big deal because it happens every day. It is a big deal because it tells women, over and over, that they are not the default human being. It is a big deal because it exhausts them. Adichie says she is angry, and she believes we should all be angry. Anger, she points out, has a long history of bringing about positive change.

For Louis, the parking attendant incident was a revelation. He finally understood that sexism was not something that happened in history books. It was happening right in front of him. It had been happening all along. He just had not been looking.

The Cage of Masculinity and the Trap of Likability

But the external slights, the waiters and parking attendants, were only half the story. The deeper damage, Adichie realized, was happening on the inside. It was happening in the minds of women who had learned to shrink themselves before anyone else could shrink them.

She turned her attention to how we raise children. This, she argued, is where the system begins. Boys are taught a specific kind of hardness. They are told not to cry, not to show fear, not to be vulnerable. They are taught that masculinity means strength, and strength means never admitting weakness. Adichie described this as trapping boys in a cold, hard cage. The result, she said, is men with "very fragile egos." Because they have never been allowed to develop genuine emotional resilience, their sense of self is brittle. It cracks easily.

And then, she explained, we raise girls to cater to those fragile egos.

Girls are taught to be likeable above all else. They are taught to be agreeable, to be accommodating, to never make anyone uncomfortable. They are taught that their success might be a threat, that their ambition might be off-putting, that their independence might make them unlovable. Adichie described this as teaching girls to "shrink themselves." To become smaller.

She offered a story that made the point painfully clear. A single female friend of hers, a successful, capable woman, was looking for a husband. She owned her own home, a nice house that she had worked hard to buy. But she decided to sell it.

Why?

Because she worried that her house would intimidate prospective husbands. She worried that a man would look at her home, at her self-sufficiency, and feel threatened. So she sold it. She made herself smaller. She removed the evidence of her success so that a man would not feel inadequate next to her.

Adichie did not judge her friend. She understood the pressure. The pressure to be less, to be palatable, to be acceptable. The pressure to pretend that you are not too much.

She told another story about a married friend. This friend grew tired of pretending to enjoy cooking more than she actually did. She had learned, like so many women, that domestic enthusiasm was part of the package. That a wife who admitted she did not love cooking was somehow failing. So she performed. She acted. She shrank her true self into a shape that fit expectations.

This was the trap. Women were not just facing external bias from waiters and colleagues. They were internalizing the bias. They were policing themselves. They were making decisions, sometimes life-altering decisions, based on the fear of threatening male egos.

Adichie made it clear that this system was not just bad for women. It was a disservice to both sexes. Men were denied their full humanity, forced into a narrow definition of masculinity that left them isolated and fragile. Women were denied their full ambition, forced into a narrow definition of femininity that left them stifled and resentful. Everyone was pretending. Everyone was performing. No one was free to be their true self.

She wanted people to understand that this was not about blaming men. It was about seeing the cage. It was about recognizing that the expectations placed on boys and girls were equally damaging, just in different ways. And it was about asking a simple question: what if we raised children differently? What if we taught boys that vulnerability was strength? What if we taught girls that ambition was not a threat? What if we focused on ability and interest, instead of gender?

But before she could answer that question, she had to address another one. The question of why this conversation was so hard to have in the first place.

Workplace Double Standards: Aggression vs. Assertiveness

Adichie had been talking about how women learn to shrink themselves. How they hide their success, pretend to enjoy cooking, sell houses to appear less intimidating. But she wanted to make something clear. This was not just about personal choices or private relationships. This was about the professional world. This was about what happens when a woman walks into a meeting, into a corner office, into a position of power.

She told the story of a friend. This woman was an American executive. She had been promoted to a high-ranking position. Her male predecessor had been known for his strict, no-nonsense style. He was admired for it. He was called "tough," "decisive," "a strong leader." When he disciplined an employee for forging a timesheet, people nodded. That was how things got done. That was leadership.

Then the woman took over. She did the same job. She held the same standards. When she disciplined an employee for the same offense, the reaction was completely different. She was called "aggressive." She was called "difficult." People said she was "hard to work with." The exact same behavior that had earned her predecessor praise earned her criticism. The only difference was her gender.

Adichie watched this happen. She knew other women with similar stories. One friend was an executive who dreaded speaking up in meetings. She had ideas, she had expertise, but she stayed silent. Why? Because she knew the cost. If she spoke with authority, she would be labeled aggressive. If she pushed back on a bad idea, she would be called difficult. If she asserted herself the way her male colleagues did, she would pay a price they never had to think about. So she let her resentments simmer. She stayed quiet. And the men around her continued to dominate the conversation.

Another friend had a different experience. She was in a meeting. She proposed an innovative idea. She laid out the reasoning, the evidence, the potential impact. The room was unimpressed. Her boss dismissed it. The conversation moved on. Then, later in the same meeting, a male colleague said the exact same thing. Word for word. This time, the boss praised him. "Great idea," he said. "That's exactly what we need."

The woman sat there. She had said the same thing twenty minutes earlier. Everyone in the room had heard her. But somehow, when she said it, it was invisible. When he said it, it was brilliant. This was not a one-time thing. This was a pattern. A double standard that operated so consistently, so invisibly, that many men did not even notice it was happening.

Adichie wanted people to understand this. The problem was not that women lacked ambition or ideas. The problem was that the same behavior was judged differently depending on who performed it. A man who spoke his mind was "confident." A woman who did the same thing was "aggressive." A man who demanded high standards was "a strong leader." A woman who did the same thing was "difficult to work with." A man who came up with an idea was "innovative." A woman who came up with the same idea was "pushy" or "trying too hard."

This double standard did not just hurt women's feelings. It hurt their careers. It silenced them in meetings. It made them second-guess every word they said. It forced them to choose between being effective and being liked. And the pressure to be liked was enormous. Adichie noticed this about her American female friends. They were powerful women. They had climbed the corporate ladder. They had broken through glass ceilings. But they were still invested in being liked. They still worried about how they came across. They still hesitated before asserting themselves.

Men did not have to worry about this. No one told a man to soften his tone. No one told a man to smile more. No one called a man "shrill" or "bossy" when he gave a direct order. Men could be authoritative without apology. Women had to navigate a minefield. Too soft, and they were not taken seriously. Too hard, and they were called a bitch. The sweet spot was impossibly narrow.

Adichie was angry about this. She said so. She was angry that women had to perform this exhausting balancing act. She was angry that the same qualities that made a man a leader made a woman a problem. But her anger was not hopeless. She believed that naming the injustice was the first step to fixing it. And the injustice was clear. The workplace was not a meritocracy. It was a system where women had to work twice as hard to be taken half as seriously. And even then, they were judged by a different standard.

She wanted everyone to see this. Not just women, who already lived it every day. But men too. The men who sat in meetings and did not notice when a woman's idea was ignored. The men who assumed their female colleagues were less competent. The men who praised a predecessor for being tough and then criticized his successor for being aggressive. They needed to see the pattern. They needed to understand that the system

was rigged. And they needed to decide whether they were going to be part of the problem or part of the solution.

Refuting Common Arguments Against Feminism

Adichie knew that not everyone would accept her argument easily. Some people would resist. They would offer reasons why feminism was unnecessary, misguided, or even dangerous. She had heard these arguments many times before. From friends. From strangers. From well-meaning people who thought they were helping.

So she took them on directly.

One of the most common arguments came from a friend who told her that feminists should see themselves as human beings first. Not as women. Just as humans. The friend meant well. He was trying to be inclusive. He thought the word "feminist" was too narrow, too divisive. Why not focus on human rights instead?

Adichie did not accept this. She understood the impulse behind it. But she also understood what it erased.

She told her friend: "There are particular things that have happened to me in the world because I am a woman."

That was the point. She did not have the luxury of pretending gender did not matter. She had been denied a role in childhood because she was a girl. She had been ignored by waiters who spoke only to the man beside her. She had been warned not to seem too ambitious, too loud, too much. These things happened to her because she was female, not just because she was human.

To use the vague term "human rights," she argued, was to deny the specific and particular problem of gender. It was to make the problem invisible. And when a problem becomes invisible, it never gets solved.

Another argument came from anthropology. Some people pointed to studies of apes. They said that in ape societies, females were submissive to males. This was nature. This was how things had always been. So why fight it?

Adichie was not impressed. "We are not apes," she said flatly. "Apes also live in trees and eat earthworms. We do not."

The logic was absurd if you thought about it. Human beings had evolved. They had built civilizations, created art, developed medicine, traveled to space. They were not bound by the behavior of animals. To use apes as a justification for gender inequality was to ignore everything that made human society human.

Then there was the culture argument. This one hit closer to home. Many Nigerians told Adichie that feminism was not part of African culture. That it was a Western import. That women in Nigeria had always been

submissive, and that was how it should stay.

Adichie rejected this completely.

"Culture does not make people," she said. "People make culture."

Culture was not static. It was not a fixed set of rules handed down from the ancestors. It was alive. It changed. It adapted. What was once considered essential to Igbo culture—like the practice of killing twins at birth—was now unthinkable. Culture had evolved. It could evolve again.

If the full humanity of women was not part of their culture, she argued, then they could and must make it part of their culture. That was not a betrayal of tradition. It was an expansion of it.

Finally, there was the argument about "bottom power." Some people told Adichie that women already had power. They could use their sexuality to influence men. They could charm, seduce, manipulate. This was power, wasn't it?

No, Adichie said. It was not.

Bottom power was not power at all. It was access to someone else's power. It was fragile. It depended on the goodwill of a man who could withdraw it at any moment. It was not the same as having your own money, your own voice, your own choices.

Real power was economic independence. Real power was being able to walk into a room and speak without needing a man's approval. Real power was not having to shrink yourself so that someone else could feel big.

Each of these arguments, Adichie showed, was a way of avoiding the real conversation. They were distractions. They allowed people to feel righteous without having to change anything.

But she refused to let them off the hook.

She wanted people to sit with the discomfort. To stop looking for excuses. To see that gender inequality was not natural, not cultural, not inevitable. It was a system. And systems could be changed.

The question was whether people had the courage to change them.

Culture is Man-Made and Can Be Remade

Adichie had dismantled the arguments one by one. The ape argument fell to common sense. The human rights argument collapsed under its own vagueness. The bottom power argument revealed itself as a fragile illusion. But the argument she saved for last was the one she heard most often in Nigeria. It was the argument that stopped conversations cold. The argument that made people nod and say, "That's just our culture."

Whenever Adichie spoke about gender inequality, someone would inevitably invoke culture as a shield. This is how things have always been, they would say. This is our tradition. This is who we are. The implication was clear: culture was a fixed, unchangeable force, and anyone who challenged it was either naive or disrespectful.

Adichie refused to accept this.

She pointed out something obvious that somehow went unnoticed: culture was constantly changing. It had always been changing. The idea that culture was a static monument handed down from ancestors was a fantasy, a convenient story people told themselves to avoid having to change.

She offered a striking example from her own Igbo heritage. There was a time, not so long ago, when the Igbo people considered the birth of twins to be an evil omen. The practice was clear: twins were killed at birth. This was not a fringe custom. It was deeply held, widely accepted, considered essential to maintaining the spiritual health of the community. Elders defended it. Families obeyed it. Generations grew up believing this was simply the way things were.

Today, that practice was unthinkable. The Igbo people looked back on it with horror and disbelief. They could not imagine killing a child because they were born a twin. Culture had changed. It had evolved. What was once considered sacred tradition became recognized as cruelty.

Adichie let the example sit. If culture could change that dramatically, that quickly, then the argument that gender inequality was "just our culture" lost all its power. Culture was not a fixed set of rules. It was alive. It breathed. It responded to new knowledge, new values, new understandings of what it meant to be human.

"Culture does not make people," she wrote. "People make culture."

This was the core insight. Culture was not some external force that descended from the sky and commanded human behavior. Culture was built by human hands, shaped by human choices, sustained by human agreement. And what humans had built, humans could rebuild.

Adichie was not arguing against culture itself. She loved her culture. She was the most interested in her family traditions among her siblings. She valued her heritage. But she refused to let culture become a prison, a justification for keeping women in a secondary position.

If the full humanity of women was not part of their culture, she argued, then they could and must make it part of their culture. This was not a betrayal of tradition. It was an expansion of it. It was culture doing what culture had always done: adapting to a more just understanding of human worth.

She understood that people feared change. Change felt like loss. When someone said "this is our culture," what they often meant was "this is what I know, this is what feels stable, this is what gives me my place in the world." But the stability of injustice was not worth preserving. The comfort of those who benefited from

inequality should not be the measure of what was right.

Adichie's argument reframed feminism entirely. Feminism was not an attack on culture. It was not a Western import designed to destroy African traditions. It was a necessary evolution of culture itself. Just as the Igbo people had evolved past killing twins, they could evolve past treating women as less than fully human.

The example of the twins did more than prove that culture changes. It proved that change was possible within the same generation. People who once believed twins were evil lived to see their grandchildren celebrate twins. The shift was not theoretical. It was real. It was lived.

Adichie wanted her readers to understand that they were living through a similar moment. The gender inequality they saw around them, the practices that seemed permanent and unchangeable, would one day seem as barbaric as killing twins. The question was whether they would wait for that future or help build it.

She was not asking anyone to abandon their culture. She was asking them to participate in its ongoing creation. Culture was not a museum. It was a conversation. And everyone had a voice in that conversation, including women who had been told their voices did not matter.

This was the hopeful message at the heart of her argument. Change was not only possible. It was inevitable. The only question was what direction that change would take. Would culture evolve toward greater justice, or would it stagnate under the weight of tradition used as an excuse?

Adichie believed in the ability of human beings to remake themselves for the better. She had seen it happen. She had watched her own culture transform in her lifetime. The killing of twins was not ancient history. It was recent enough that living people remembered it. And yet it had become unthinkable.

Gender inequality could become unthinkable too. If people had the courage to name it, challenge it, and insist that their culture could be better than it was.

"Culture does not make people," she repeated. "People make culture."

The power to change was already in their hands.

Conclusion: A Call to Do Better for Everyone

The power to change was already in their hands. Adichie had made that clear. Culture was not a fixed monument. It was a living thing, shaped by every generation that inherited it. And if people had the courage to name the problem and insist on something better, change would come. The question was not whether it was possible. The question was whether enough people would choose to make it happen.

Adichie returned to where she had started. She thought about Okoloma, the childhood friend who had first called her a feminist all those years ago. She had not known what the word meant at the time. She had only

known that his tone was not kind. It was not a compliment. But now, looking back, she could say with certainty that he had been right to call her a feminist. He had simply been wrong about what that meant.

She had looked up the word in a dictionary long ago, after that argument. The definition was simple. A feminist was a person who believed in the social, political, and economic equality of the sexes. That was all. Not a man-hater. Not an angry woman who refused to shave. Not someone who hated bras or African culture or makeup. Just someone who believed that men and women should be equal. It was a definition so straightforward that it seemed almost impossible to argue with. And yet so many people did argue with it. So many people had turned the word into an insult, a label to be avoided, a mark of shame.

Adichie wanted to reclaim that word. She wanted to strip away the baggage that had been piled on top of it and return it to its original meaning. She had called herself a feminist for years, even when others warned her not to. She had worn the label proudly, even when it cost her. And she believed that more people should do the same. Not because feminism was about women being better than men. Not because it was about punishing men or blaming them. But because it was about something far simpler and far more urgent. It was about equality.

She thought about her great grandmother. The woman had lived in a time when the word feminist did not exist in the language she spoke. She had never heard it. She had never read it. She had never been called one. And yet, by every measure that mattered, she had been a feminist. She had been a woman who refused to accept the limitations placed on her. She had been a woman who pushed back against the expectations of her culture. She had been a woman who believed, without ever having the vocabulary to name it, that she deserved the same dignity and freedom as any man.

Adichie's great grandmother had been a feminist before the word existed. She had lived it without ever being able to name it. And that was the point. Feminism was not a Western import. It was not a modern invention. It was not something that had been imposed on African culture by outsiders. It was a belief that had existed in every culture, in every generation, wherever women had refused to accept less than they deserved.

And it was not just for women. Adichie made sure to say this clearly. She talked about her brother Kene. Kene was a kind, good-looking, and very masculine young man. He was not the kind of person that most people would picture when they heard the word feminist. And yet he was a feminist. He believed in equality. He supported the women in his life. He did not feel threatened by their success or diminished by their strength. He understood that feminism was not about taking something away from men. It was about giving everyone the same chance to be fully human.

This was the heart of Adichie's message. Feminism was not a battle between men and women. It was a partnership. It was a recognition that the rigid roles assigned to both genders harmed everyone. Boys were raised to be hard and stoic, trapped in a cage of masculinity that left them unable to express vulnerability or

admit weakness. Girls were raised to shrink themselves, to cater to fragile egos, to make themselves smaller so that men could feel bigger. Both were diminished by this system. Both deserved better.

Adichie did not pretend that change would be easy. She did not offer a simple checklist or a five-step plan. She knew that the patterns of inequality were deeply ingrained, passed down through generations, reinforced by countless small moments that seemed harmless on their own but added up to something enormous. But she also believed that change was possible. She had seen it happen. She had watched her own culture transform in her lifetime. She had seen practices that once seemed permanent become unthinkable. She believed that the same could happen with gender inequality.

The final words of her essay were not complicated. They were not poetic or grand. They were simple and direct. They were a call that applied to everyone, regardless of gender, regardless of background, regardless of whether they had ever thought of themselves as feminists before.

"All of us, women and men, must do better."

That was it. That was the message. Not blame. Not anger, though anger had its place. Not condemnation, though there was plenty to condemn. Just a simple, honest plea for everyone to look at the world as it was and decide to make it better.

Adichie had started her essay with a memory of being called a feminist as an insult. She ended it with a definition and an invitation. A feminist was simply someone who believed in equality. And that was something everyone could be. Not because feminism was easy. Not because the work was done. But because the alternative was unacceptable. A world where half the population was denied full humanity was a world that had failed. And it was a world that could be changed.

She believed in the ability of human beings to remake themselves for the better. She had said that earlier in the essay, and she meant it. She had seen it happen in her own life. She had seen it happen in the lives of people around her. She had watched as friends and strangers and even skeptics came to understand what feminism really meant. She had watched as men like her brother Kene embraced the label without fear. She had watched as women like her great grandmother lived it without ever having a name for it.

The word feminist carried a lot of weight. It had been twisted and distorted and turned into something ugly. But Adichie was not afraid of it. She was not willing to abandon it just because others had misused it. She was not willing to let the stereotypes win. She wanted to reclaim the word, not because it was perfect, but because it was necessary. Because the problem of gender inequality was real and specific and could not be solved by pretending it did not exist or by hiding behind vague terms like human rights.

The essay ended where it began, with Okoloma and the argument they had had as children. She could not remember what they were arguing about. She only remembered the word he had used and the way he had said it. She had spent years thinking about that moment. She had spent years trying to understand why the

word had felt like an insult. And she had come to a conclusion. It was not the word that was the problem. It was the world that had made it one.

The world could change. Culture could change. People could change. That was the hope Adichie offered. Not a guarantee. Not a promise that everything would be easy. But a belief that it was possible. And a call for everyone, women and men, to do their part.

All of us must do better. That was not a suggestion. It was not a gentle recommendation. It was a call to action. And it was addressed to everyone who heard it.